

Bleeding Faultlines

Allegations of votebank politics fly thick and fast even as many lives are lost in an eruption of violence across four districts

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Daljit Singh, an army soldier, never thought he would see something like this, much less remain a mute spectator. Less than 500 m from where he was standing, around 5,000 people, armed with daggers and knives, shouted 'Pakistan Zindabad' before embarking on an orgy of violence. As ethnic clashes between Bodos and immigrant Muslims from Bangladesh broke out, 49 died and 1.5 lakh were rendered homeless. The bloodletting that soaked four districts of Assam—Udalguri, Darrang, Sonitpur and Chirang—had a colour, and it was a Pakistani green.

It all started with the All Assam Students' Union (AASU) organising a state-wide eviction drive against illegal migrants in the second week of August. Tension between Bodo villages and the surrounding ones, inhabited mainly by immigrants, grew amid allegations that terrorist elements like Harkat-ul-Jihad-e-Islami and SIMI were active among them. Rakesh Swargiyari, a Bodo youth caught stealing a goat from

RUNNING SCARED: Armymen escorting villagers to safer zones

the Muslim-dominated village of Mohanpur in Udalguri, was the trigger. When he returned home badly thrashed, his tribesmen decided to retaliate. Mohanpur's Muslims rose to the violence of the occasion, and the communal powder-keg exploded.

"They came in huge numbers, set ablaze our houses and killed our men. We fled to live," said Mahendra Brahma of Bhakatpara village in

BITOPAN BORBORAH



Darrang district who saw a Pakistani flag hoisted near his burnt house.

Most people in the relief camps—whether Bodos or Muslims—are not keen to return to their homes as they have lost faith in the administration. Though the Government has deployed army and paramilitary forces, the Bodos claim they don't feel safe even in the camps as they think that the Government is protecting the immigrants. "The Bangladeshis hacked three men in front of the superintendent of police. All that the police did was to fire blanks," says Anthonik Sangmas of Punia village. Land is the key to the conflict that has now persisted for several decades. Illegal Bangladeshi settlers have used a variety of means to entrench themselves, even infiltrating into the tribal belts and blocks created by the Government to prevent tribal land alienation.

Chief Minister Tarun Gogoi said, "National Democratic Front of Bodoland (NDFB) was behind this violence and that no Pakistani flags were hoisted anywhere." In contrast, Assam police chief R.N. Mathur said there was no evidence about the extremist group's involvement. Gogoi has ordered a judicial inquiry, but it's evident the authorities don't know what's going on. Political parties, meanwhile, are trying to milk the situation for electoral benefit. The ruling Congress has said the Opposition is trying to fan the flames; the Opposition blames the Government for building a nexus with the illegal migrants. "It's not correct to brand all the Muslims as Bangladeshi just to appeal to the popular sentiments. It will further alienate the community," says Assam government spokesman and state Health Minister Himanta Biswa Sharma. "The Government has formed a sinister nexus with the immigrant Bangladeshis to protect their vote-bank. Soon foreigners will decide the fate of Assam," alleges Samujjal Kumar Bhattacharya, adviser, AASU.

As peace returns gradually, the Government now faces the daunting task of sending the displaced people back to their homes. **by Kaushik Deka**

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